

Berkeley Neighbors for Housing & Climate Action 2026 Candidate Questionnaire

Candidate Name: Igor A. Tregub

District / Office being sought: Berkeley City Council, District 4

1. Berkeley's Housing Element lays out the city's plan for new housing construction through 2031, ensuring the city can meet its Regional Housing Needs Allocation (RHNA) of ~9,000 homes across a range of income levels.

The Housing Element commits Berkeley to a number of major policy changes in order to meet state requirements for affirmatively furthering fair housing, including a San Pablo Specific Plan and upzoning along North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave, among other items.

What is your view on the Housing Element and these policies? What are the most important things we need to do to implement the City's Housing Element?

Please discuss your ideas and priorities around:

- a. San Pablo specific plan
- b. Zoning for housing in high-resource commercial areas like North Shattuck, Solano, and College Ave
- c. Extending 'middle housing' zoning to some parts of the Hills, while balancing fire risk
- d. Other strategies for Berkeley to affirmatively further fair housing

- a. *A refresh of the San Pablo specific plan is a key priority of this City Council, and I support efforts to harmonize the 2025-2033 RHNA's housing production goals – particularly along transit corridors such as San Pablo and University Avenue – with project approvals that I have supported on the Council, and, prior to it, in my 12 years on the Zoning Adjustments Board. In the area west of Sixth Street, I support preserving Berkeley's artisanal and light manufacturing sector for small- and medium-sized businesses while allowing for gentle residential density that has been unlocked through the City Council's recent, unanimous approval of Middle Housing zoning. The University-San Pablo commercial node is intended to be a gateway to Berkeley and yet three of the nodes at this time sit in a vacant and uninviting state. Increasing residential density near these nodes and improving the walkability and accessibility of adjacent public commons are key strategies to reopen the corner stores or other community-serving uses at this intersection and revitalize this important area.*

Any plan to enhance housing production opportunities along transit corridors must also come with improved ability to realize the carrying capacity of these corridors to alternatives to private-owned vehicles. My ideal vision would be to upgrade the 72R bus rapid network from mere signal prioritization to full-on Bus Rapid Transit (particularly on those stretches of San Pablo that are most heavily impacted during rush hour). San Pablo Avenue improvements are heavily dependent on buy-in from Caltrans and MTC

(which is in the process of releasing a strategic plan for region-wide San Pablo Ave. upgrades). In my opinion, this process has been going too slowly and on occasion (as in the case of real-time signage on I-80 directing traffic to San Pablo Ave) going in the wrong direction. If re-elected, I will continue to support my Districts 1 and 2 colleagues in addressing this issue, and, if called upon, am happy to use the working relationships I've amassed over decades of serving our beloved community to help build a coalition of fellow elected officials who represent jurisdictions that include the San Pablo corridor to help expedite these or other kinds of regional solutions.

- b. When it comes to the Council, I intend to vote for a version of the Corridor Zoning Update proposal and very likely will support the recommendation approved by the Berkeley Planning Commission, which provided a higher level of density than the proposal recommended by Planning staff (https://berkeleyca.gov/sites/default/files/2026-04/2026-05_06_PC_Item%2010A_Corridors.pdf). It is important for me, and the council as a whole, to make good on our obligation to affirmatively further fair housing in resource-rich areas. I will note that a tailored approach framework was recommended as part of the Planning Commission's 7-2 vote.*

While my support for a tailored approach to the CZU may represent a compromise from a more housing-forward alternative, I will note that other important housing measures that passed the council unanimously, including the Middle Housing Ordinance, were inherent compromises because the unanimity of the vote to advance housing was important to us on the Council.

My support for a version of the CZU stems from my taking seriously our jurisdiction's obligation to affirmatively further fair housing under AB 686, as it is a significant way to continue to redress the intergenerational structural harms caused by the 20th century pattern of redlining and racist zoning covenants.

- c. While I felt then, and continue to feel now, that the Middle Housing Ordinance as approved by a unanimous City Council in 2025 was, in and of itself, provided an appropriate and suitable balance between providing more opportunities for first-time homeownership through gentle density in residential areas while balancing fire risk, I am open to considering changes if the ordinance is not working as effectively as it was intended to do.*
- d. I have supported Councilmember Humbert's PITCH proposal and voted in support of it twice (at both the full Council level and to move it out of the Land Use Policy Committee with a qualified positive recommendation). It would:*
 - 1. Rezone the Telegraph Avenue corridor south of Parker Street to the Oakland border at Woolsey Street from the current C-C (Commercial-Corridor) district to the C-T (Telegraph Avenue Commercial) district (or similar), allowing for taller mixed-use*

housing development, with a goal of base zoning of 8 stories/85 feet, potentially adjusted to optimize production of affordable inclusionary units.

- 2. Identify and upzone specific auto-oriented C-N (Neighborhood Commercial) parcels in the Claremont and Ashby area (near Domingo Avenue) from their current 2–3 story limits to 4–6 stories using existing or new zoning districts.*
- 3. Allocate funding from the District 8 office budget to begin required planning, General Plan amendments, and/or California Environmental Quality Act (CEQA) review for the proposed zoning changes.*

2. Berkeley's Climate Action Plan sets forth a goal of 80% reduction in greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions by 2050. Today, the two major sources of GHG emissions in Berkeley are from gas-powered automobiles and natural gas used in buildings.

Berkeley has a variety of plans and programs intended to help address these emissions, including the Electric Mobility Roadmap and the Berkeley Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Other related efforts include the Bicycle Plan and Pedestrian Master Plan, as well as the City's now-defunct natural gas ban on new buildings.

What is your view on the Climate Action Plan and these strategies? What are the most important things we need to do to address greenhouse gas emissions?

Berkeley has always led the way on climate, often through my leadership. As a clean energy policy expert and Berkeley's representative to the Ava Community Energy Board, I have prioritized making Berkeley the first carbon-free city in the nation through successful efforts to reduce building emissions; expand public EV charging infrastructure; and invest in climate-resilient community gathering spaces, localized solar energy, battery storage, and community microgrids—with an emphasis on supporting renters with access to affordable renewable energy.

In my two years on the Council, I brought my decades of professional and volunteer experience working at local, state, and federal levels to combat climate change to hit the ground running and pick the baton up from efforts championed by the immediate past D4 Councilmember, including shoring up our Building Electrification Ordinance which was unfortunately struck down by a conservative panel of the Ninth Circuit Court; expanding Berkeley's fleet electrification program; partnering with colleagues on a Berkeley Green New Deal; and strengthening a just and equitable transition and jobs training program for the installation of renewables.

Just a few climate initiatives on which I have led over the past two years on the Council have included the following:

- Authored a council item to support a strong stance of NO! to coal being transported through our communities - to be heard at Council on September 15*
- Continuing efforts to plug the hole left by the Ninth Circuit Court's overturning of Berkeley's gas ban through the use of energy reach codes for new and existing construction;*

- Authored and actively soliciting funding for Oxford for All, which will ensure that several high-traffic blocks of the Oxford corridor by the UC Berkeley campus are made more safe for bicyclists and micromobility users
- Co-sponsored and participated in workshopping sessions for several Green New Deal items championed by Councilmember Taplin, including the latest workforce development item
- Co-sponsored and participated in Berkeley's first Sun Day event
- Authored a Resolution of the City of Berkeley Supporting the Bay Area Air District's Zero Emission Building Appliance Rules and spoke in support of it at the Bay Area Air District
- Authored a resolution in support of the Polluters Pay Climate Act and have continued to advocate for it as a new bill is introduced at the state level
- Authored a resolution in support of what eventually became the Utility Accountability Act (SB 332)
- As the Ava Community Energy representative to the City of Berkeley, I was appointed to chair the Management, Regulatory, and Legislative Committee which helped advise the agency on a solid track record of getting bills signed into law that advanced community choice energy and expanded distributed energy while defeating bad proposals. I also helped navigate a successful agreement for Ava to partner with cities like Berkeley to bring community resiliency centers into our neighborhoods, despite headwinds incurred by the transition away from the net energy metering 2.0 and investment tax credit at the state and federal levels, respectively.
- Worked with the Sierra Club to defeat AB 942, which would have made housing, including multifamily housing, with solar more expensive.
- Serve as Berkeley's representative and Vice Chair of the Lead Abatement Joint Powers Authority
- Served on the Mayor's Envision 2050 task force, where, along with my chief of staff, we provided guidance into the climate sections of the document
- Successfully amended a motion at Ava Energy to invest an additional \$3 Million (\$1 Million above the staff recommendation) toward Ava's successful e-bike pilot - good for rebates for 2400 additional e-bikes and e-trikes.

3. In your opinion, what was the most important City Council vote on Berkeley's housing crisis in the past four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

I am particularly proud of helping build consensus on the Council to get to a unanimous vote for the Middle Housing Ordinance. The gentle increase in by-right residential density contemplated in this item has not only helped redress of one vestige of racist zoning covenants which Berkeley spearheaded in the early 20th century but has been among the most significant opportunities in decades to help lower the cost of housing in residential neighborhoods and provide families with first-time homeownership opportunities. Just after being elected to the Council two years ago, I hit the ground running, hosting several community listening sessions on the various Middle Housing proposals while making my office accessible and available to neighbors who wished to discuss both their support for the concept and their concerns. I was

pleased that, through my office's efforts, some of my constituents who initially expressed skepticism ended up supporting the item when it came to the Council for a final vote and that I was able to work with my Council colleagues in a collaborative and constructive ways to "meet in the middle" on the different proposals, thus helping pave the way to a historic unanimous vote.

4. In your opinion, what was the most important climate or environmental issue faced by the Berkeley City Council in the last four years? Briefly describe the issue, what you think of the Council's decision, and what you would have done had you been on the Council. For incumbents, please describe why you voted the way you did, and what you think now about that vote.

While I am continuing to diligently work towards plugging the hole left by the Ninth Circuit Court's upending of Berkeley's first-in-nation gas ban for new buildings, in less than a year on the Council, my efforts helped get to a unanimous Council vote on a just-as-significant policy intervention. The City of Berkeley's Building Emissions Saving Ordinance (BESO) is a first-in-the-nation program to cut pollution and boost utility affordability and climate resilience by modernizing homes when they are sold. The policy ensures that when a home changes hands, it has 21st Century upgrades that will help lower energy bills, improve health and safety during extreme weather events, and decrease air and climate pollution. Under the new policy, if upgrades are needed, home buyers can choose from a menu of options, including heat pumps, solar and batteries, panel upgrades, insulation, EV chargers, and more.

The adoption of BESO was a key implementation action of the Climate Action Plan (CAP). Existing buildings are the second largest source of greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions and account for 43% of GHGs in Berkeley's most recent emissions inventory. The recent BESO amendments furthered Berkeley's environmental sustainability and climate goals, including becoming a Fossil Fuel Free City; decreasing emissions by 60.5% from 2018 levels by 2030 under its Race to Zero commitment; being responsive to its Declaration of a Climate Emergency and Just Transition framework; and spurring jobs in building electrification.

In order for Berkeley to achieve its climate, GHG reduction, resilience, and public health goals, all buildings will need to transition off fossil fuels to clean electricity. Requiring buildings to complete upgrades at time of sale is one of the four primary strategies adopted by City Council through Berkeley's Existing Building Electrification Strategy. Berkeley would not be able to achieve its GHG emissions reduction goals without adopting time-of-sale upgrade requirements for small residential buildings, which constitute 84% of Berkeley's building stock.

Like many local jurisdictions, the City of Berkeley is also grappling with significant budgetary constraints. As such, any such program needed to be cost-neutral to the City while ensuring that achieving Berkeley's climate action goals do not pose an undue burden to new homeowners.

The new BESO policy, unanimously adopted by the Berkeley City Council in 2025 and implemented on January 1, 2026, initially applies to single-family homes and duplexes and

expands to buildings with up to four dwellings in 2028.

With the new policy, if a home doesn't yet meet resilience standards, the buyer can choose from a menu of upgrades, including heat pumps, solar and batteries, panel upgrades, insulation, EV chargers, and more, that will make the home meet the resilience standard. Different upgrade options earn different amounts of credits, and a home buyer would need to complete one or more upgrades to reach the required number of credits within two years of the sale. Homes that already have at least one heat pump system, are all-electric, or where sellers have made sufficient upgrades in the five years before the sale will not need to make additional upgrades.

The BESO amendments establish a flexible resilience standard for small residential buildings based on a credit system. Building owners who have already taken steps to reduce emissions by installing a heat pump-based water heater or HVAC system are not required to complete additional upgrades. This standard only applies to properties that are being sold.

The resilience standard uses a credit-based compliance system to ensure the greatest flexibility. Building owners can choose which measures to complete to accommodate the range of building conditions and owner priorities. Each measure has a corresponding credit value based on its emissions savings. Measures that contribute to resilience but don't directly reduce emissions have credit values based on cost, and bonus credits were added to some measures that provide additional health or safety benefits.

For more information, see <https://berkeleyca.gov/construction-development/green-building/building-emissions-saving-ordinance-beso> and <https://berkeleyca.gov/sites/default/files/documents/2025-02-11%20Item%2009%20Proposed%20Amendments%20to%20the%20Building.pdf> as well as local media coverage at <https://www.berkeleyside.org/2025/04/17/berkeley-city-council-proposed-beso-amendments> .

5. To achieve its RHNA goals, Berkeley must continue to build homes for all income levels. These new residents will need to travel within Berkeley. Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions from transportation comprise roughly 60% of total emissions in Berkeley.

How would you ensure that Berkeley continues to reduce GHG emissions while adding new homes?

Transportation impacts accounts for the brunt of Berkeley's and most other urban municipalities' GHG emissions. Minimizing or eliminating parking in urban cores and along transit corridors, where housing should be built, is unlikely to induce demand for more parking, particularly when couple with the condition we put into projects that occupants of these units, to the extent that they are in Restricted Preferential Parking (RPP) zones, will not be eligible for parking permits. Doing so is more likely to do the opposite - increase the opportunity to cut emissions in the most significant sector contributing to these GHG emissions in the first place. Applicants and members of the public alike know me as someone who tends to question projects that appear to

be overparked. I have been doing this before it was popular or cool, and my championing the elimination of subterranean parking at the deeply affordable Hope Center in the heart of our downtown was a major contributor of it being able to get built. I have followed this up by vocally supporting a Berkeley change from parking minimum to parking maximum standards in housing projects, which were a blueprint for a state law that was subsequently adopted. On the council, I have been a consistent champion of housing over parking (with a narrow exception around ensuring an adequate amount ADA accessible spaces where feasible) and will continue to be.

6. Walking and biking presents opportunities to help Berkeley residents reduce their GHG emissions, but safety concerns can be a major deterrent.

What is your perspective on how we should address pedestrian and cyclist safety on our streets?

In my time in office, I have focused on making Berkeley streets safe for everyone, including seniors, people with disabilities, strollers, and rollers. My efforts have led to progress big and small, including reimagining Oxford Street as one that is safe for users of all modes of transit, investing in safer pedestrian crossings throughout District 4, and the Council's adoption of a regulatory framework for the safe use of shared micromobility devices. Every day, I put my good working relationships with leaders at BART and AC Transit on the city's behalf—including being entrusted by my peers to serve as chair of the AC Transit Parcel Tax Oversight Committee—to partner on more affordable, plentiful, and seamless ways to get around the Bay Area region.

My priorities in the next term, if re-elected, will be to advance initiatives we started, such as the implementation and the securing of additional funding for Oxford for All (<https://its.berkeley.edu/news/city-planning-students-pave-way-oxford-street-improvements>) – ranked by my peers on the Council as one of the top 10 priorities through the Reweighted Rank Voting (RRV process) and a bevy of additional safer crosswalk improvements throughout District 4 which are close to being fully funded but need an additional nudge. Outside of the district, I voted, along with six of my colleagues, to move forward with a study of a protected bike lane along several segments of the Hopkins corridor.

I am also deeply and broadly supportive of efforts to set aside the public commons for non-car traffic, helping move the District 7 Car-Free Telegraph proposal into another top priority for the Council while, along with the Mayor, working to secure funding for a car-free Center Street between Shattuck and Oxford.

7. Berkeley has a long history of using zoning, restrictive covenants and redlining to achieve racial and economic segregation. This history continues to shape Berkeley today.

Recent research by the Turner Center at UC Berkeley suggests that inclusionary zoning requirements, which mandate on-site restricted affordable housing in new developments, may have the effect of reducing overall housing construction, including the production of affordable

units. However, on-site affordable housing can also be an effective tool for desegregating neighborhoods.

What is your perspective on how Berkeley should use inclusionary zoning requirements, versus other affordable housing development options (such as in-lieu fees)?

This is an area in which we have over the years had robust discussions as to the level appropriate to still provide housing opportunities and allow market-rate housing to pencil, I recognize that - especially in the current economic climate - fees, taxes, and mandates that are overly burdensome and costly can hurt the goose that lays the golden egg and may result in perverse disincentives to provide housing opportunities for those at a variety of income levels. I have demonstrated, through my actions on the dais, a track record of working with stakeholders across a variety of perspectives and use an evidence-based approach to thoughtfully develop policies that reflect these varied perspectives and are responsive to the facts on the ground. It is my intention to continue developing and strengthening a working relationship with this organization should I have the opportunity to continue to be of service to my constituents.

In terms of the debate between inclusionary housing and an applicant of market-rate units paying the Affordable Housing Mitigation Fee (AHMF) into the Housing Trust Fund, I appreciate the respective advantages and drawbacks of each of these solutions and, all else being equal, wish to leave the ultimate decision to the applicant. With the advent of new statewide zoning laws, the inclusion of a certain percentage of on-site housing can maximize the production of housing at multiple income levels (including market-rate housing) through an increased density bonus percentage. On the other hand, the payment of the AHMF into the Housing Trust Fund is money well spent, particularly once leveraged with regional, statewide, and even federal funding (to the extent the latter is available these days and may become available again in the future).